MANDAL REPORT IMPLEMENTATION, 1990

Spark that Lit a Social Revolution

What was perhaps as much a political expedient as the desire for social justice soon took on a life of its own, ushering in the era of caste-based politics and a growing competition among communities for quotas in jobs and education

BY KAUSHIK DEKA

When a young student—Rajiv Goswami of Delhi's Deshbandhu College—set himself afire on September 19, 1990, to protest then prime minister Vishwanath Pratap Singh's decision to implement the recommendations of the Second Backward Classes Commission, or the Mandal Commission, his harrowing act of defiance became an enduring symbol of resistance in the country and exposed the fragility of India's social fabric.

Set up in 1979 by the Morarji Desai government and chaired by former Bihar chief minister Bindheshwari Prasad Mandal, the commission proposed 27 per cent reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in central government jobs and educational institutions. The report languished in obscurity for 11 years, till Singh retrieved it from the dustbin of history and announced its implementation on August 7, 1990.

Some saw it as a long-overdue step toward social justice, others dismissed it as an open political gambit to consolidate OBC support. But the announcement provoked intense backlash from the members of the privileged castes, who perceived it as a diminishing of their opportunities in a reservation-driven system. Two years later, the Supreme Court, in a landmark judgment—*Indra Sawhney vs. Union of India*—upheld the 27 per cent quota for OBCs, introduced a 50 per cent cap on total reservations, and introduced the 'creamy layer' concept.

Mandal unequivocally altered India's political landscape, laying the ground for caste-based parties such as the Samajwadi Party and the Bahujan Samaj Party in Uttar Pradesh and the Rashtriya Janata Dal in Bihar and giving rise to powerful leaders like Lalu Prasad Yadav in Bihar and Mulayam Singh Yadav and Mayawati in UP. In a parallel development, the BJP countered Mandal with what came to be called Kamandal politics. L.K. Advani launched his Ram Rath Yatra in October 1990, in a bid to unify Hindus across castes under a Hindutva umbrella.

The genie that Mandal unleashed is alive and kicking three decades on. If anything, dominant communities—the Patidars in Gujarat, the Jats in Haryana and the Marathas in Maharashtra—are agitating to join the OBC bandwagon and avail

DID YOU KNOW?

5,013 castes are now recognised as OBCs by the central government, a significant increase from the 3,743 identified by the Mandal Commission in 1980

63 PER CENT

Share of OBCs in Bihar's population, suggesting a rising number from 52% assumed in Mandal report

